

# Leiden University – Research Integrity Governance

## A. Sources Shortlist

- **Commissie Wetenschappelijke Integriteit – Universiteit Leiden (Organisatiegids)** – Official page outlining Leiden University's Scientific Integrity Committee, its two-chamber structure (for the University and LUMC), the complaints procedure, and contact details <sup>1</sup> <sup>2</sup> .
- **Wetenschappelijke integriteit – Universiteit Leiden (Research & Integrity Policy)** – University webpage describing the importance of scientific integrity at Leiden, referencing the national Code of Conduct (2018), the internal complaints procedure, the role of the confidential counsellor (vertrouwenspersoon), and educational efforts to promote research integrity <sup>3</sup> <sup>4</sup> .
- **Klachtenregeling Wetenschappelijke Integriteit (2019)** – Official regulation (NL/EN) detailing the appointment, composition, and duties of the Academic Integrity Committee of Leiden University & LUMC, as well as the role of confidential advisers and the procedure for handling integrity complaints <sup>5</sup> <sup>6</sup> .
- **Vertrouwenspersoon Wetenschappelijke Integriteit – UL Staff Site** – Internal staff page explaining the confidential adviser's role as the first point of contact for questions or concerns about academic integrity, emphasizing confidentiality and guidance in the complaint process (includes contact info for integrity counsellors) <sup>4</sup> <sup>7</sup> .

## B. Extracted Facts

- **Office name:** *Commissie Wetenschappelijke Integriteit* (Academic Integrity Committee). This university-wide committee investigates allegations of scientific/academic misconduct by Leiden University employees (including LUMC staff) <sup>1</sup> . The committee operates alongside **confidential counsellors for scientific integrity**, who provide advice and informal mediation but are not part of the committee.
- **Institutional location:** The Academic Integrity Committee is a central university committee. Its **administrative secretariat is housed within the Legal Affairs department** of the university's Executive Office <sup>8</sup> <sup>9</sup> . The committee is composed of professors from all faculties, ensuring representation across disciplines <sup>1</sup> . (Since 2018, the Leiden University and LUMC integrity committees have merged into one committee with two chambers for each institution <sup>10</sup> .)
- **Reporting line:** The committee is formally **appointed by and reports to the Executive Board** (College van Bestuur). After investigating a complaint, the committee issues an advisory report to the Executive Board, which then makes the final decision on the case <sup>11</sup> <sup>6</sup> . (If a complaint concerns an Executive Board member, the advice goes to the Supervisory Board instead <sup>6</sup> .)
- **Legal involvement:** The **Legal Affairs department is directly involved** in supporting the integrity process – the committee's official secretaries are legal staff members <sup>8</sup> and the secretariat (contact point for complaints) resides in Legal Affairs <sup>9</sup> . One of the two committee chairs is required to be a jurist (legal expert) <sup>12</sup> . The complaints procedure is governed by a formal regulation, ensuring due process and alignment with legal and ethical standards <sup>5</sup> <sup>6</sup> .
- **Decision authority:** **Decision-making power lies with the Executive Board.** The Academic Integrity Committee itself does *not* impose sanctions; it delivers findings and a recommendation on

whether a complaint is founded <sup>11</sup>. The Executive Board decides whether to accept the committee's advice and determines any consequences or sanctions if a violation is confirmed <sup>11</sup>. (The Board's decision, along with the committee's report, is communicated to both complainant and accused. Parties who disagree can appeal for an external second opinion before the decision is finalized.)

- **Case-handling model: Complaint intake:** Any person (internal or external) may file a formal complaint alleging a breach of academic integrity by a (former) staff member of Leiden University or LUMC <sup>13</sup> <sup>14</sup>. Complainants can seek preliminary advice or mediation from a **confidential adviser for academic integrity** before lodging a complaint, but this step is optional <sup>15</sup>. **Investigation:** The complaint is submitted directly to the Committee's secretariat (Legal Affairs). If the complaint meets formal requirements, the Academic Integrity Committee will investigate it according to the university's complaint regulation and the Dutch Code of Conduct for Research Integrity <sup>16</sup>. The Committee gathers evidence, obtains a response from the accused, and holds a hearing where both parties can present their views <sup>17</sup>. **Recommendation and decision:** The Committee then formulates an **advisory report on the merits of the complaint** and forwards it to the Executive Board <sup>11</sup>. The Executive Board decides whether to adopt the advice and what measures (if any) to take. The Board's decision (together with the committee's advice) is provided to both parties <sup>11</sup>. **Appeal:** If either party disagrees with the outcome, they may request a second opinion from the national **LOWI** (Landelijk Orgaan Wetenschappelijke Integriteit) within a specified time frame <sup>18</sup>. The LOWI will review the case and procedure and issue a non-binding opinion. After the LOWI process, the Executive Board makes a **final decision** on the complaint <sup>18</sup>. Throughout the process, strict confidentiality is maintained by all involved <sup>19</sup>.
- **Independence indicators:** The integrity committee is structured to be impartial within the institution. Its members are **senior academics (professors)** and **no sitting administrators** – by rule, **Executive Board members, faculty deans, and confidential advisers cannot serve as committee members or chairs** <sup>5</sup>. This prevents conflicts of interest with university management. The committee has a broad faculty representation and can even co-opt external experts as ad hoc members for specific cases if needed <sup>20</sup>. The **confidential counsellor (vertrouwenspersoon)** role is kept separate and independent from the committee (they have a confidentiality duty and do not participate in investigations or decisions) <sup>21</sup>. Additionally, an external check is built in: the LOWI appeals process provides an independent review of contested cases before the university's final ruling <sup>18</sup>. The committee's mandate and procedures are codified in official regulations, underscoring its objective and rule-based operation <sup>6</sup>. (The committee also publishes periodic **annual reports** on its activities, enhancing transparency about how cases are handled, within the limits of confidentiality.)

## C. Evidence Snippets

- *Institutional location:* “**werkzaam bij de afdeling Juridische Zaken van het Bestuursbureau**” (the committee secretaries **work at the Legal Affairs department of the Executive Office**) <sup>8</sup>.
- *Reporting line:* “...the committee formulates its advice ... and **submits it to the Executive Board. The Executive Board then decides whether to adopt the advice...**” <sup>11</sup>.

## D. Open Questions

- **Independence of process:** Aside from excluding top administrators from the committee, it is not explicitly stated how the committee's independence is safeguarded in practice. For example, does the committee operate entirely free from executive influence when conducting investigations, given

that its secretariat is within the Executive Board's office? This remains unaddressed in the public documentation.

- **Role in student misconduct:** It is unclear whether the Academic Integrity Committee's mandate extends to handling research misconduct allegations involving students (e.g. PhD candidates or student researchers) or if it strictly covers employees. The policies focus on "(ex-)employees," suggesting that cases of student plagiarism or exam fraud are handled by other bodies (examination committees), but this delineation is not explicitly described on the university's sites.
- **Sanction implementation:** While the Executive Board decides on measures if a violation is found, the exact nature of possible sanctions and how they are enforced (e.g. by faculties or HR departments) is not detailed publicly. The guidance on what actions can be taken (retractions, disciplinary measures, termination, etc.) is not specified in the available sources.
- **Preventive efforts coordination:** The university highlights training and preventive measures (like integrity education in curricula and PhD programs <sup>22</sup>), but it is not clearly stated **which office or officials coordinate these efforts**. There doesn't appear to be a dedicated "integrity office" beyond the committee and confidential counsellors. It remains somewhat unclear how ongoing integrity promotion (seminars, oversight of integrity policy implementation, etc.) is managed and whether the Academic Integrity Committee or another entity oversees these initiatives.
- **Reporting and oversight:** The committee produces annual reports on its activities <sup>23</sup>, but it's not stated to whom these are reported or if any oversight body (e.g. the University Council or an ethics board) reviews the university's handling of integrity cases. The transparency of outcomes is limited to internal records and the LOWI process; the extent of external oversight beyond LOWI is not documented.

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<sup>1</sup> <sup>2</sup> <sup>8</sup> <sup>18</sup> <sup>23</sup> Commissie Wetenschappelijke Integriteit - Universiteit Leiden

<https://www.organisatiegids.universiteitleiden.nl/universitaire-commissies/commissie-wetenschappelijke-integriteit>

<sup>3</sup> <sup>4</sup> <sup>10</sup> <sup>13</sup> <sup>15</sup> <sup>21</sup> <sup>22</sup> Wetenschappelijke integriteit - Universiteit Leiden

<https://www.universiteitleiden.nl/onderzoek/organisatie-van-ons-onderzoek/kwaliteit-en-integriteit/wetenschappelijke-integriteit>

<sup>5</sup> <sup>6</sup> <sup>12</sup> <sup>20</sup> Klachtregeling Wetenschappelijke Integriteit Universiteit Leiden en LUMC

<https://www.organisatiegids.universiteitleiden.nl/binaries/content/assets/ul2staff/reglementen/onderzoek/klachtenregeling-wetenschappelijke-integriteit-2019-nl.pdf>

<sup>7</sup> Wetenschappelijke integriteit - Universiteit Leiden

<https://www.medewerkers.universiteitleiden.nl/po/sociale-veiligheid/vertrouwenspersonen/wetenschappelijke-integriteit>

<sup>9</sup> <sup>11</sup> <sup>16</sup> <sup>17</sup> <sup>19</sup> Academic Integrity Committee - Leiden University

<https://www.organisatiegids.universiteitleiden.nl/en/university-committees/academic-integrity-committee>

<sup>14</sup> Overeenkomst

<https://www.organisatiegids.universiteitleiden.nl/binaries/content/assets/ul2staff/organisatiegids/klachtregeling-wetenschappelijke-integriteit-2018-eng.pdf>